happy but he was still in awe of the Chinese. A R&AW officer, who worked at the China desk at the time, was of the opinion that Rajiv suffered from a mental block created by the defeat inflicted on India by China in 1962 when his maternal grandfather Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru was the prime minister. Although he was briefed that there was nothing to fear from the Chinese, Rajiv stood like a school boy meeting the principal when he paid a visit to Deng Xiaoping, chairman of China's Central Military Commission in December 1988.'

Rajiv also kept the agency on its toes thanks to his ill-conceived decision to send peacekeeping troops to Sri Lanka, said R&AW insiders who still believe that this decision destroyed several R&AW operations in the neighbouring country. Rajiv Gandhi's successors V.P. Singh and Chandra Shekhar were not interested in India's foreign policy and paid little attention to the R&AW operations abroad. R&AW officers believe these two decision makers' primary aim was to establish a political legacy rather than look into the effectiveness and value of India's spy agency and the intelligence inputs and strategic analyses on various countries and events it provided. However, an officer code-named Prince had a different view. He said that the R&AW didn't care about political masters and between Rajiv's and Chandra Shekhar's regimes, the agency launched some spectacular spy operations.

This book explores the hits and misses of the espionage operations through the eyes of spymasters who are rarely in T20 masalamatch mode. Courting a spy can be tougher than digging out a yorker. It requires endless wet evenings in bars, hours in dimly lit listening posts and miles-long walks to understand the nitty-gritties of espionage operations. But the results can be thrilling.